Music, Politics, and Pleasure: Live Soca in Trinidad

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Since the 1990s, the commercial value of soca has been widely recognized. Soca's socio-cultural and musical accomplishments, however, remain contentious and contested. Soca's so-called light lyrics and its emphasis on sexualized bodies and pleasures, associated in particular with the 1990s onward, have contributed to its dismissal by many. Judged against calypso's sociopolitical commentaries, soca has been criticized by numerous journalists, academics, calypsonians, politicians, and listeners for not engaging the political. At a time of escalating rates of crime and violence and growing fears about personal and public safety in Trinidad, soca is regularly condemned for failing to address the country's social ills. Still, over the past two decades soca has repeatedly succeeded in gathering large crowds, sometimes numbering over twenty thousand, at shows and fêtes.

As a participant in some of these audiences, I want to offer an ethnographic perspective on the cultural work that live soca performs. As anthropologist Kevin Birth aptly remarks, "Ethnographic work on contemporary musical performance and consumption can play a complementary role to historically-oriented scholarship on Trinidadian music by capturing dimensions of musical experience that are not readily preserved in the historical record."[1] In this essay I focus on live performances of soca from 1993 onward to highlight their transformative capabilities. My premise is that live performances are effective, that is, do cultural work,

1 Kevin Birth, *Bacchanalian Sentiments: Musical Experiences and Political Counterpoints in Trinidad* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2008), 26.

small axe 31 • March 2010 • DOI 10.1215/07990537-2009-041 © Small Axe, Inc.

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in ways that cannot be reduced solely to the grid of resistance or solely to the outcomes of capitalist reproduction.[2] I want to move away from thinking of "the political" in popular music only in terms of opposition and instead show the ways in which, through pleasure, soca fosters distinct skills, knowledges, and civic values.[3] In this sense, my study is not about pleasure per se but about the *politics of pleasure* that animate soca performances. Part of a larger project, it highlights the social intimacies and antagonisms live soca performances help produce, dismiss, and reinforce.

Public Intimacies and Exclusions

A significant part of the cultural work that live soca performances achieve occurs through the creation of *intimacies*. I do not use *intimacy* in terms of what Lisa Lowe describes as its "more common [meaning] of privacy, often figured as conjugal and familial relations in the bourgeois home";[4] instead, drawing on Lowe's critical insights, I use the word two other ways: to address the variety of contacts among people that soca makes possible and to speak about the spatial proximity it helps create.[5] These two different types of intimacies enabled by live performances of soca could be referred to as *public intimacies*, since during the performances they unfold among artists on stage, between the artists on stage and their audiences, and among audience members. I want to stress that public intimacies at live soca performances are necessarily performative, that is, embodied practices that reiterate identities and produce discursive effects that articulate cultural understandings of things such as race, class, gender, and sexuality. To focus on the public intimacies enabled at live soca performances is thus useful to highlight how new points of connections are being developed (for example, among artists and audience members of different ethnicities, nationalities, and generations, and across musical genres), and how the lines between the private and the public are being reworked (for example, what can and cannot be publicly shared or exposed). To focus on public intimacies as governing technologies further helps to address both their emancipatory and their repressive potentials—that is, their politics of inclusion and exclusion of distinct musical sensibilities and sexual orientation, among others.

The public intimacies executed at live soca performances also need to be acknowledged as productive of pleasure, and, as Sylvia Yanagisako argues in relation to sentiment in general, pleasure in turn needs to be recognized as a productive force.[6] Pleasure is indeed not just

2 See Natasha Barnes, "Body Talk: Notes on Women and Spectacle in Contemporary Trinidad Carnival," *Small Axe*, no. 7 (March 2000). "Live performance, as recent theorization in performance studies reminds us, has transformative capabilities that can exist independent of capitalist reproduction and co-option when experienced in live encounters" (98).

3 For further elaboration on what pleasure in music enables, see Monique Guillory and Richard C. Green, eds., *Soul: Black Power, Politics and Music* (New York: New York University Press, 1998).

4 Lisa Lowe, "The Intimacies of Four Continents," in Ann Laura Stoler, ed., *Haunted by Empire: Geographies of Intimacy in North American History* (Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 2006), 195.

5 For further elaboration on these understandings of "intimacies," see Ann Laura Stoler's insightful study, *Carnal Knowledge and Imperial Power: Race and the Intimate in Colonial Rule* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2002).

6 See Sylvia Yanagisako, *Producing Culture and Capital: Family Firms in Italy* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2002). Yanagisako explains, "Under particular conditions, sentiments generate particular desires and incite particular social

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central to soca music making. It is a vital force in soca community formation and consumer loyalty.

Among Soca Artists

Soca artists on stage have produced what *Trinidad Express* columnist Keith Smith calls "a flood of collaborations."[7] These collaborations greatly contrast with the practice of calypsonians, who rarely share the stage during their presentations, except when performing *picong*, the competitive satirical or taunting verbal exchange in song with other calypsonians. Based on the local normative conception in the calypso milieu of an artist as one who combines expressive skills in poetry, dance, and singing, the "true, true" calypsonians—to use a local expression—are expected not only to produce their own material but also to be judged on their own merits as solo artists in calypso competitions. Inspired by the musics that they have listened to since the 1990s (most particularly Jamaican dancehall, and rock, pop, and hip-hop from the Anglo-American mainstream), soca artists have transgressed several calypso conventions. A great majority acknowledge composing songs in collaboration, and these songs often feature several singers performing different sections—a practice that challenges calypso competitions' prior judging of solo artists only. Machel Montano, one of the chief exponents of new trends in soca, explains that these changes enact a notion of authenticity in soca profoundly different from the ways in which calypso has been traditionally defined. It is more a matter of resonating with soca artists' particular experience than of being faithful to an established tradition. In Montano's view, what makes soca songs "authentic" is that they are a "reflection of us"—a reflection of the new visual and sonic environments that soca artists experience on a daily basis.[8]

Based on this perspective, Smith points out that collaborations in soca entail a variety of contacts: for example, between younger soca artists and veterans of calypso (Shurwayne Winchester and Calypso Rose), between male and female artists (Machel Montano and Destra Garcia), between two artists of different ethnicities (Rikki Jai and Black Stalin), between artists from different islands (Machel Montano, from Trinidad, and Alison Hinds, from Barbados), between artists from different musical genres (Machel Montano, associated with soca, and Shaggy, with dancehall), and between artists living on the island and in diaspora (Bunji Garlin, in Trinidad, and David Rudder, a Trinidadian living in Toronto; Machel Montano, in Trinidad, and Wyclef Jean, a Haitian living in New York). The collaborations also revel in mixing linguistic accents and sounds as well as rhythms and clothing from different countries and musical genres.

actions" (10). She adds, "Sentiments, themselves the products of historically contingent cultural processes . . . influence and shape material production" (11). For an elaboration of these points in relation to soca, see Jocelyne Guilbault, *Governing Sound: The Cultural Politics of Trinidad's Carnival Musics* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2007).

7 Keith Smith, "A Flood of Collaborations," *Trinidad Express*, 19 January 2007.

8 Machel Montano, quoted in Guilbault, *Governing Sound*, 207.

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These various kinds of collaborations—or *intimacies* performed in and for the public—combine, as Smith remarks, different talents and knowledges that, to the delight of the artists involved as well as of their audiences, have produced hits, great shows, and massive parties, and musically have produced, to use Smith's own words, "impressive results." When the CD *Collectors Riddim* appeared in 2003, it created a sensation. Based on *riddim*—a Jamaican technique involving the production of a prerecorded rhythm section track over which several singers are invited to compose their own tunes—*Collectors Riddim*, produced by Xtatik Ltd and Xtatik 5.0, featured a prerecorded soca rhythmic track with a hint of ska played by a short riff on the synthesizer over which Trinidadian guest artists performed their original compositions. The soca-based *Collectors Riddim* assembled musical techniques, rhythmic patterns, musical creativities, and voices that arguably contributed to the originality of the CD and the great amount of airplay it received.

In relation to my second definition of *intimacy*—spatial proximity—soca collaborations in live performances bring together bodies that have rarely ever performed together in the same space, let alone on the same stage, for example, Afro-Trinidadian Bunji Garlin and Indo-Trinidadian Sarika Mahabir and Jamaican Red Rat and Trinidadian Machel Montano. Such performances combine on the same stage artists with differing ethnicities who share a common nationality and artists with different nationalities who share a common racialization. In perfoming this way, these soca artists confirm and help reinforce in both sound and sight what Smith describes as "the essential and increasing inter-connectedness of this thing called Trinidad music."[9] In interviews, soca artists speak of the joy and satisfaction they derive from bringing together the familiar and the less familiar face and sound, the brother and the sister, the elder and the neighbor, and also musical memories and new musical know-how. They embrace what Edouard Glissant powerfully refers to as *the poetics of Relation* that has been constitutive of the Caribbean's history and vitality, or what Birth, inspired by Glissant, calls *the aesthetics of relation*, to emphasize the many relationships—sonic and social, in varied styles and strengths with Africa, North America, India, Jamaica, and England, among others—that music (in this case, soca) makes possible.[10]

Yet, although soca performs togetherness on stage, it has nonetheless excluded certain interconnections. Soca artists reinforce heteronormative relations, and so far have excluded homosexual expression.[11] In other words, not all pleasures are permissible on the soca stage. *Wining*—a local term referring to the gyrating of the waist—is still performed alone or usually between a man and a woman.[12] In the same vein, the hypersexualization of bodies through

9 Smith, "A Flood of Collaborations."

10 See Edouard Glissant, *Poetics of Relation*, trans. Betsy Wing (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1997); and Birth, *Bacchanalian Sentiments*, 16.

11 For further information on the subject, see Jennifer Rahim, "(Not) Knowing the Difference: Calypso Overseas and the Sound of Belonging in Selected Narratives of Migration," *Anthurium* 3, no. 2 (Fall 2005), http://anthurium.miami.edu/volume_3/issue_2/rahim-notknowing.htm (accessed 20 October 2009). Although the author refers to calypso, her remarks also apply here.

12 While I have seen some women occasionally wine on each other, I have never seen a similar public performance between men.

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outfits and performance gestures amplifies prescribed gendered roles and performances of women as feminine and of men as masculine. Women wear outfits tightly following the contours of their figures: low-cut, short tops highlight the breasts and expose the buttocks in a style that conforms to widely shared heterosexual aesthetic values in the Caribbean. Men perform *djouk* movements (pelvic thrusts) on women invited to come on stage, or they touch their crotches à la hip-hop to assert their masculinity.[13] Both soca male and female artists embody and (re)produce salient aspects of the conventions that inform how femininity and masculinity are construed by a vast majority of Afro-Trinidadians of the "oil boom generation" born in the 1970s.[14] These conventions draw not only from past Afro-Trinidadian gender politics but also from the ways currently articulated by artistic peers in other African diasporas, particularly in Jamaican dancehall and American hip-hop.[15]

While performers may adopt conventional gendered outfits and dispositions, they can still challenge normative expressions of sexuality and of secularity. For instance, when Denyse Belfon demands that a man wine on her on stage, she transgresses the normative notion of a woman's agency in its appropriate public expression. And when Machel Montano invokes Krishna in his song "Harry Krishna" (1998), he transgresses a highly policed divide between the religious and the secular.

Among Artists and Audience Members

Soca performances produce public intimacies that are sources of pleasure not only among the artists performing on stage but also between the artists and their audiences. Soca greatly relies on an *aesthetic of participation* that "ties together emotion, cognition and physical action."[16] From 1993—when Superblue launched his song "Bacchanal Time," in which he urges the crowd to jump up and wave their rags[17]—until now, soca singers have contacted their audiences through call-and-response: "Anybody from Trinidad? Anybody from Antigua? Anybody from Grenada?" They coordinate the crowd's body movements with theirs, creating a sea of bodies in motion—"Move to the right, move to the left; start to wine; go down

13 On this subject, see Rhoda Reddock, ed., *Interrogating Caribbean Masculinities* (Kingston: University of the West Indies Press, 2004).

14 I owe this expression to Robin Balliger, "Noisy Spaces: Popular Music Consumption, Social Fragmentation and the Cultural Politics of Globalization in Trinidad" (PhD diss., Stanford University, 2000). Balliger, following local usage, employs it to refer to the generation born during the economic boost provided by Trinidad's oil industry during the 1970s.

15 For further information on these musics in relation to gender politics, see Carolyn Cooper, *Sound Clash: Jamaican Dancehall Culture At Large* (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2004); Donna Hope, *Inna di Dancehall: Popular Culture and the Politics of Identity in Jamaica* (Kingston: University of the West Indies Press, 2006); and Dawn M. Norfleet, "Hip-Hop and Rap," in Mellone V. Burnim and Portia K. Maultsby, eds., *African American Music: An Introduction* (New York: Routledge, 2006), 253–91.

16 Birth, *Bacchanalian Sentiments*, 15. I borrow the expression "aesthetic of participation" from Jeff Packman, "'We Work Hard at Entertainment': Performance and Professionalism in the Popular Music Scenes of Salvador da Bahia, Brazil" (PhD diss., University of California, Berkeley, 2007). Such focus on an aesthetic of participation is not new in Trinidad. In his 1967 study, Jacob Elder notes how antiphonal singing in Trinidadian music had remained "socially significant" (quoted in Birth, *Bacchanalian Sentiments*, 24).

17 The expression "wave your rag" refers to waving something in the air—it can be any piece of cloth or a flag. Such motion represents a way to mark one's active participation in the show and one's support and loyalty to the artist.

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low." Soca artists urge members of the audience to find a partner and wine, then they often stop the music and keep only the skeleton of the rhythm section accompaniment, so that performers and audience relax together and "breathe" (as Montano puts it in his 2005 song "You"). Someone in the crowd waves a huge Trinidadian flag; several audience members press themselves against the fence that separates them from the space reserved for the security guards and journalists and the stage where their favorite artists now speak and address them. Others just stand where they are, nearly still until their song leader unleashes the pulsating rhythm animating the song, the backup singers come in, and the entire band exults, playing the chorus at full volume—sonically calling everyone to join in, feel the beat, and jump up and wave together with the soca artists and other dancers on stage.

For soca artists as well for their audiences, the focus of live performances is interaction—sensual, emotional, and physical. It is about sharing the experience of a moment, a pulse, a movement. It is about engaging in a form of sociality.[18] The variety of contacts or public intimacies that soca artists establish with the crowds ranges from expressing together one's sense of national belonging ("Anybody from Trinidad?") to establishing "affective alliances"[19] through the sharing of feelings—exuberance, joy, and exhaustion (through "Jump up," "Wave your rag," "Hold on to your partner"). Most important, it also includes showing signs of reciprocal loyalty between artists and audience members, and of solidarity among one another. When Destra sings to her audience, "Together we jumping / No racist no color define / Soca is we energy baby," in her 2006 song "Max It Up," and when she adds, "We chippin in file in one harmony / We defying poverty," she is not just sharing her world vision. She is fostering a sense of community together with her audience members. In her line "Is all ah we, so support yuh soca music, yes yuh identity," she includes herself as part of the community and simultaneously calls on the audience members to support soca because, as she puts it, it enacts who they are, their "identity" (note her use of the singular).

While the call-and-response and dance movements performed by the artists on stage and the audience members create a shared knowledge of lyrics and tunes, and an aesthetic appreciation of sexualized bodies and moves—a kind of intimacy through shared knowledge that helps create a sense of "we"—they simultaneously produce the outsider, the "stranger." Kezia Page takes up this issue by addressing the 2001 winning road-march song, "Stranger," by Shadow, one of the most acknowledged Trinidadian artists among both calypsonians and soca performers since the mid-1970s. She explains, "Shadow, a kind Trinidadian man, teaches

18 For additional perspectives on soca's "commands," see Robin Balliger, "Popular Music and the Cultural Politics of Globalisation among the Post–Oil Boom Generation in Trinidad," in Ralph R. Premdas, ed., *Identity, Ethnicity and Culture in the Caribbean* (St. Augustine: University of the West Indies School of Continuing Studies, 1998), 54–79. See also Gordon Rohlehr, "'We Getting the Kaiso That We Deserve': Calypso and the World Music Market," *The Drama Review* 42, no. 3 (1998): 82–95; and Birth, *Bacchanalian Sentiments*.

19 I owe this expression to Lawrence Grossberg, "Another Boring Day in Paradise: Rock and Roll and the Empowerment of Everyday life," in Richard Middleton and David Horn, eds., *Popular Music 4: Performers and Audiences* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1984), 225–58.

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a white Australian woman how to dance and how to enjoy Carnival."[20] The song, according to Page, "is ironically not for strangers, but is a first place [*sic*] mobilizer for insiders who already know what to do when he shouts 'rag' and 'flag.'" In other words, insiders find in Shadow's narrative "a kind of power and pleasure, as they dance along with the fictional stranger—only better." Page adds, "In effect, Shadow, by making a spectacle of the outsider strengthens the bonds of the insider community, for here, knowing the dance is the way one indicates her/his place in the community."[21] Significantly, it should be noted, soca songs such as "Stranger" provide privileged moments for returnees, who have come back to resettle permanently in Trinidad, as well as for Trinidadian and other Caribbean emigrants who have come back to the island for Carnival: by participating as "insiders" they can experience a sense of belonging in an environment otherwise often hostile to them.[22]

As Page indicates, "Stranger" echoes many other songs in the Trinidadian Carnival music repertoire.[23] And, like them, it does more than just reinforce a sense of community "by drawing borders through what might be termed a choreographic map." It also effects "a power shift between tourist and local." Implicit in the "Stranger" is an evocation of tourism and sex.

> While these women might have expected to take advantage of friendly and easy access into Caribbean entertainment, they are in fact the ones who are exploited as they are made into spectacle and perhaps worse. . . . [While] the follow-along lyrics, with dance instructions included, on one hand seem to extend the dance community and thus the consumer community in an ingeniously welcoming gesture . . . , these same lyrics by making fun of outsiders and making unsuspecting insiders of people along just for the dance are clearly more than just welcoming.[24]

Pleasure in live performance of soca songs like Shadow's "Stranger" is not innocent. It transforms audience members "in-the-know" into subjects of community and, simultaneously, constitutes the outsider as the necessary, even welcome—yet not fully accepted—counterpart of its formation.[25] In so doing, pleasure then becomes a productive force of power.

20 Kezia Page, "'Everybody do the dance': The Politics of Uniformity in Dancehall and Calypso," *Anthurium* 3, no. 2 (Fall 2005), http://anthurium.miami.edu/volume_3/issue_2/page-everybody.htm, paragraph 6 (accessed 20 October 2009).
21 Ibid., paragraph 7.
22 For further information, see Dwaine E. Plaza and Frances Henry, eds., *Returning to the Source: The Final Stage of the Caribbean Migration Circuit* (Kingston: University of the West Indies Press, 2006).
23 In "'Everybody do the dance,'" Page refers to Lord Kitchener's "Miss Tourist" (1968) and Colin Luca's "Dolla Wine" (1991) as further examples of songs that, like "Stranger," explore the theme of easy dance instructions for tourists. According to her, such themes have been popularized again over the last five years.
24 Page, "'Everybody do the dance,'" paragraph 19.
25 Here, I draw on Jean-François Bayart's essay "Total Subjectivation" and his insightful discussion of Michel Foucault's problematic of *assujetissement*, in Jean-François Bayart and Jean-Pierre Warner, eds., *Matière à politique: Le pouvoir, les corps et les choses* (Paris: Kathala, 2004), 215–53.

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Among Audience Members

Live soca permits a variety of contacts and spatial proximity among audience members that produce visceral exuberance and intense delight. Typically soca competitions, shows, and parties during Carnival draw massive crowds, often more than twenty thousand people. Jumping up and down in close physical proximity to one another, people in the audience take pleasure in moving together and sharing the high volume of sounds pulsing from the speakers. It is a time not so much for conversation as for co-action. As Josanne, a soca partygoer explains, "You know the lyrics, you know the choruses, and you sing along. Gearing up for the season, the music is on the radio. Once Christmas is done, it is time for carnival. Radio stations that do not [usually] play soca now play soca. So you listen to the songs, learn the lyrics, and sing along at the party."[26] As I have experienced as an audience member at soca parties and competitions over the past sixteen years and as many soca fans in Trinidad shared with me, waving your rag together, singing along, and rolling your waist in time and in tune with others gives a sense of closeness. For women, wining alone or on a man (a much emphasized dance movement in soca) is part of the sensual pleasures—public intimacies—enabled through soca. Moving to the right or moving to the left along with the person standing next to you and the one in front of or behind you in effect gathers together people (who are often unrelated) in synchrony and, for that moment, in intense awareness of each other. Participation in such events literally embodies a visceral sense of collective belonging.

This belonging is in fact experienced on multiple levels. In addition to sharing the space and moving together with the massive crowd assembled for the occasion, in Trinidad (and in many other places) participants share this event with their *posse*, the smaller group of people with whom they usually attend large public events. As a friend recounts,

> When you are going to a soca party, most likely you are not going alone. You got to have your posse. You meet up with your friends, a group of you going. . . . You organize the transportation or they are picking you up. But you are not getting there at . . . you know, usually the party is, say, from 9 o'clock to whatever, but you are not going at 9 o'clock. You are getting there by 11 o'clock when things are hot. You don't want to start the party, basically, right? You are getting there and things are jamming. And you get there and you party till 6 in the morning, 7 in the morning.[27]

Going with your posse amplifies the pleasure of attending a live soca show. As Birth cogently remarks, it helps reinforce bonds of affection among friends and kin and furthermore offers protection.[28] Dancing and singing together with familiar faces and bodies heightens the sense of togetherness and provides the space for letting go—"going down low, jumping

26 Interview with the author, Port of Spain, January 2007.
27 Interview with the author, Berkeley, California, February 2009.
28 Kevin Birth insightfully describes the importance of posse in attending soca live performances. For further information on the subject, see his book, *Bacchanalian Sentiment*. See also Daniel Miller, *Modernity: An Ethnographic Approach—Dualism and Mass Consumption in Trinidad* (Oxford: Berg, 1994), and "Absolute Freedom in Trinidad," *Man* 26, no. 2 (1991): 323–41.

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up, and getting on bad." It also provides a sense of security in being surrounded by friends who care—literally—for each other. Hardly possible otherwise, male friends moving together clear the way across the thick crowd to get close to the stage; girlfriends accompany each other to get a drink; male friends come in close to their female friends to discourage unwanted suitors or drunk dancers; male and female friends move together to the right, move to the left, and wave their rags in the air while the sheer assembling of their bodies physically creates a safe space—and enough space—to do all this. Getting high hearing and seeing your favorite soca star, exerting yourself by dancing through the party tunes, and sensually exulting with the volume of sound and dance moves of the large crowd *with your posse* does intensify pleasure and provide a sense of safety—and it does something more. It produces collective memories that further bond the group together;[29] it enables the recall of affective relations over time.

The intense focus on participation in soca, cultivated by the numerous call-and-responses in the songs and by the equally numerous dance commands (move to the right, jump up, and wave) uttered by soca artists, unmistakably generates crowd movements, as has been widely reported. But while soca participation addresses the collectivity, the audience as a whole, it does not erase the individuality, the soca fan in the audience. The commands of dance movements and the call-and-response prompted by the soca artists, not to mention the unspoken dress code for live soca shows or parties, become—even for just a moment—the rules of the game, to use Michel Foucault's expression. Similar to the way C. L. R. James references cricket, live soca performance is a group activity with a rigid structure (at least for some observers), yet requires individual style and creativity: "What matters in cricket, as in all the arts, is not finer points but what everyone with some knowledge of the elements can see and feel. It is only within such a rigid structural frame that the individuality so characteristic of cricket can flourish."[30] Along these lines, while most women with whom I spoke agree that to attend a live soca show or party you must dress not only to be comfortable but also, most important, to look "sharp and sexy," they also agree that you cannot wear the same things that other people wear. Otherwise, in their words, "You better go home and change." Individual distinction in soca events does not disappear just because in such events many performing acts are coordinated. As in most games, soca musical performances involve individual style while doing group movements. This is the case in relation to not only how people dress but also how people dance. While jumping up or wining among the audience members may appear synchronized, these dance movements never are—completely. Nor is there any attempt to make them so. Similarly, when soca artists engage the crowd in a call-and-response, the audience members make no effort to blend their voices in unison. On the contrary, to sing with

29 I owe this insight to Birth. See Birth, *Bacchanalian Sentiments*, 110.
30 C. L. R. James, *Beyond a Boundary* (1963; Durham, NC: Duke University Press, 1983), 197–98.

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your own voice loud and clear is part of the soca aesthetics. To paraphrase C. L. R. James, the individual seeks individuality in collective actions.[31]

Soca live performances, it should be emphasized, also attract large crowds for the self-pleasure and energy they provide to individuals—to the stars as well as to audience members. These performances encourage you to *play yuhself*, to use the Trinidadian expression, that is, "to enjoy yourself to the fullest or to express yourself to the extreme as only you are able to do."[32] While you may not sing the lyrics of your favorite soca songs at home, at the show you loudly, and with great confidence, join the chorus's voices. Rarely in your day-to-day life do you have an opportunity to jump up and down and allow yourself to wine at a fast tempo until your body feels loosened up as when soca stars' singing and bands' playing fill the air and create the festive and energizing atmosphere that entices everyone to move to the same beat. Dancing with your own style the well-known dance movements and trying out a new move may give you joy and perhaps the bonus of a smile from someone nearby. The singing out loud and the physical demands put on your dancing body at a live soca performance may take a toll on your throat and feet, but these actions bring a feeling of exhilaration.

The play yuhself, or the "care for the self," as Foucault would put it, that live soca performances enable through singing, waving, and dancing does not, however, take place in a vacuum. As Foucault argues, this care for the self is "ethical in itself, but it implies complex relations with others in the measure where this ethos of freedom is also a way of caring for others."[33] In other words, to play yuhself at soca parties does not imply that you can do anything you please to attain a certain state of happiness or freedom; it involves a relation with others that may at times encourage or prevent certain expressions.

That live soca performances create spaces that invite sociality and encourage public intimacies has been widely acknowledged in the press and in academic publications. What has been less often addressed is the price that audience members must pay, both literally and metaphorically, to access and engage in these spaces. Pleasure does not come free. It is linked to several other realities—socioeconomic and state related, as well as that of gender politics—that have a direct impact on who can participate in soca fêtes and how different audience members experience them.

While live soca aims to assemble as many people as possible and, to use Montano's words, "to bring back the love," the cost of tickets makes many of these performances inaccessible to some.[34] While many popular fêtes may cost only TT$45 to attend (around US$7.35,

31 "The mass is not merely passive. . . . The film strip, radio drama are a form of art which must satisfy the mass, *the individual seeking individuality in a mechanized socialized society*" (emphasis mine). C. L. R. James, quoted in Anthony Bogues, "C. L. R. James and the Politics of the Subject, Culture and Desire," in Christopher Gair, ed., *Beyond Boundaries: C. L. R. James and Postnational Studies* (Ann Arbor, MI: Pluto, 2006), 164.

32 Carol Martin, "Trinidad Carnival Glossary," *The Drama Review* 42, no. 3 (1998): 232.

33 Michel Foucault, "The Ethic of Care for the Self as a Practice of Freedom," *Philosophy and Social Criticism* 12 (Summer 1987): 118.

34 Machel Montano, in an interview with Cordielle Street, "HD," *Guardian* (Trinidad), 5 February 2007.

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at the time of this writing), during 2007 Carnival some of the most sought-after fêtes had ticket prices ranging from TT$80 to TT$250, an amount of money many cannot pay. These prices are prohibitively expensive for the most marginalized lower-class subjects, who themselves are often excluded from hegemonic constructions of the public. From the outset, soca fêtes thus include only those people who can afford them.

In turn, the several thousand people who can attend soca competitions, shows, or fêtes are confronted with a reality of another sort that is state related rather than economic and concerns the issues of traffic jams and safety on the road (related to speeding and drunk driving). The worsening of such problems every year has caused many participants—ironically, on their way to experience the public intimacies and pleasures enabled by soca—to feel deep resentment at the state's incapacity to address these issues. So, in an uncanny way, live soca performances lead their audiences to address state politics in relation to personal and public safety by voicing critiques on at least three matters: the lack of material infrastructure for improved roadways; the lack of police enforcement of driving regulations; and, thus, the overall lack of delivery of social services and state planning. Attending live soca performances is not—and should not be seen as being—experienced at the exclusion of other engagements, in this case, voicing critiques of public infrastructures and services.

While the dynamic performance of soca songs enables the expression of sexual dancing and pleasure, there are other realities that mark the ways these expressions are controlled. Although everyone in attendance is encouraged to jump up and wine, many people in the audience are not entirely free to really let go and "break away." Norms of propriety for many middle- and upper-class members of the audience—for both men and women, but more so for women—do not entirely disappear, and these norms condition many of the ways that their bodies can move in dancing. Similarly, couple relationships can place limits on how close one of the partners can be to other people in the crowd. Fights can erupt when a man is seen as wining too closely on what calypsonian the Mighty Duke once called another man's "property"—that is, his wife or girlfriend.[35] So class values and affective relationships intervene in how and to what extent soca audience members experience pleasure.

Over the past few years, the escalating rate of crime and violence in Trinidad, combined with the massive and rowdy crowds attending live soca performances, have in turn heightened how class differences have influenced the ways some people now experience those performances. Inadvertently, both crimes and crowds have created new opportunities for the organizers of live soca performances to make more money and for members of the middle and upper classes, as well as tourists with money, to assert their privileged position. The "VIP Treatment," as it is called, refers to the special treatment that people paying high entrance fees receive. This includes access to protected spaces with their own facilities, food, and drink services where well-to-do guests can enjoy the fête with—and, at the same time, at a distance

35 For an elaboration on the subject, see Maude Dikobe, "Doing She Own Thing: Gender, Performance and Subversion in Trinidad Calypso" (PhD diss., University of California, Berkeley, 2003); and Miller, "Absolute Freedom in Trinidad."

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from—the masses. A crucial desire here is to be immersed within, but safely insulated from, rowdy crowds. The energetic tempo of soca songs, the full-throated call-and-response of the song leader and crowd, the high volume of the musical accompaniment, and the sexual moves performed by the artists on stage and audience members produce distinct kinds of public intimacies and, by extension, different kinds of pleasure—safer for some than for others.

By way of conclusion, I want to return to the question of what projects and practices can be deemed to engage the political. In this essay, I have argued that the political can be articulated in ways other than through words or by being related to state politics, as it has often been conceived in Trinidad and in many other countries.[36] I have shown that live soca performances articulate a variety of contacts and spatial proximities through sounds, sights, sexualized bodies, and movements, and provide a great source of pleasure for soca artists and audience members. Seeing pleasure as a productive force, I have thereby highlighted how through pleasure critical cultural politics are performed.

On stage, soca artists enjoy crossing entrenched divides of ethnicity, race, and nation. New musical sensibilities, knowledges, and practices emerge from soca artists' numerous collaborations. As demonstrated by the massive crowds attending live soca shows and parties, audience members revel in the new musical creations emerging from these numerous collaborations as they help redefine or reinforce the audience's own politics of belonging within multiple constituencies on an international stage. At the same time, the physical proximity of people and the moving of bodies together engage interactions and co-actions that, for many participants, give a sense of closeness and of collective belonging. As Birth eloquently puts it, in reference to Superblue's song "Get Something and Wave" and other soca songs composed in the same vein, "The coordinated movements evoked by Trinidadian music [soca] are not aimed at creating conformity or inculcating discipline, but at creating *experiences of relation* and permitting spontaneity."[37] In this perspective, live soca performances may enact the kind of poiesis, "the imaginative structures," to which C. L. R. James was alluding, that enable people (in this case, the soca performers and their audience members) to reconfigure their humanness and affirm their desire for forms of life.[38] This is what the soca artists' performances and their songs may be trying to do when they invite experiences of relation and call for solidarity.

While soca artists and their songs work particularly hard at "bringing back the love" and reconfiguring humanness, they also cultivate an effusive sense of belonging on multiple levels. At their shows and parties, soca artists assemble audiences from all parts of the Caribbean

36 For further elaboration on the subject, see Birth, *Bacchanalian Sentiments*, 102.
37 Birth, *Bacchanalian Sentiments*, 224 (emphasis mine).
38 Here I paraphrase Sylvia Wynter's description of Jamesian poiesis: "The 'imaginative structures' to which James calls our attention are the ways in which humans reconfigure their humanness, the ways in which representations become constitutive of culture and society. In this frame, sports, art and other forms of so-called cultural representation become the sites from which human beings affirm their desire for forms of life" (quoted in Bogues, "C. L. R. James," 168).

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and diasporic locations. Yet when they make this call in their songs—"Anybody from Trinidad? Anybody from Antigua?"—they powerfully help renew their audiences' sense(s) of national belonging, their distinctiveness within the Caribbean and abroad. On a smaller scale, live soca parties also provide opportunities for friends and kin to gather and reinforce the affective links that unite them as a posse: at the event by enjoying together the live performance and after the event by remembering this experience of relation. At yet another level, soca events enable individuals to *play yuhself*—that is, to enjoy and express themselves to the fullest in moves, sounds, and sights (how they look), and to feel a stamina and an energy that take care of the self in tangible and meaningful ways. This practice of freedom, to use Foucault's expression, is, however, always enmeshed in complex relations and informed by the ethics that govern one's relation with and care for others—ethics that can be informed by marriage, class, and gender politics, among others.

Whether they are instantiated through politics of exclusion or the varied conditions in which audience members may participate, power relations are actively deployed and negotiated through live soca performances. Expressions of heterosexuality on stage and among audience members dominate to the exclusion of any other expression of sexuality. Ticket pricing keeps lower-class people away from several sites where some soca events unfold and in so doing tends to reinforce the closely knit community of middle- and upper-class people. In turn, the production of the "we"—based on a shared knowledge of the artists and their songs, the typical body movements, and the permissible spatial proximities and sensual and sexual expressions—makes those "in-the-know" the subjects of a community and makes the others the outsiders.[39]

The "choreographic mapping" of soca communities, to use Page's expression, and the practice of freedom (play yuhself) that soca events enable is managed through several other realities that greatly condition the ways in which audience members may participate. At soca shows and parties, norms of propriety for members of the middle and upper classes highly govern the ways men and women can dance and let go. In turn, whether the soca participants are from the lower, middle, or upper class, gender politics in soca events continues to place the burden of responsibility of "behaving properly" primarily on women—with proper behavior defined in various ways, according to class, religion, relationships, ethnicity, and so on. Spaces at soca shows and parties that offer additional security officers, facilities, and other bonuses reinforce class divisions by being accessed exclusively by middle- and upper-class participants and well-off tourists who can afford them.

39 In that sense, one could speak about "pleasure-knowledge," an expression coined by Lauren Berlant, whose evocation of Foucault's famous expression "power-knowledge" produces significant links among pleasure, knowledge, and power. For further information on the subject, see Berlant's introduction to "Intimacy: A Special Issue," *Critical Inquiry* 24, no. 2 (Winter 1998): 284.

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Rather than endorsing the normative opposition between pleasure and politics, this study underscores the productive political force of pleasure in soca performances.[40] The cultural work enabled by these performances focusing on pleasure—in all cases, be it emancipatory or repressive—needs to be further assessed.

40 See Stuart Hall, "Editorial," *New Left Review*, no. 1 (1960). In this first issue of *New Left Review*, Hall writes about the danger of conceiving politics in terms that are too narrow. In his view, this was "a main cause of the decline of socialism in this country [Britain]" (1). As he explains, the socialist rhetoric was too stodgy; it needed to reach out to popular culture and therefore to contemporary forms of public pleasure.

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